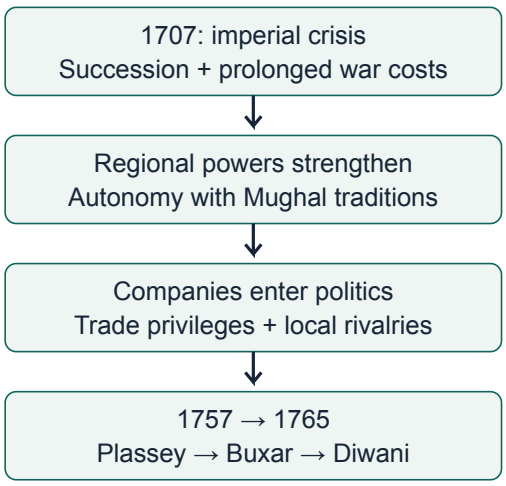
Decline of Mughal Empire

1. The eighteenth century: transition, not inevitable conquest

- **1707:** Aurangzeb's death ended the era of the Great Mughals; decline had begun during his reign. Effective imperial power contracted long before the dynasty's final removal in **1857–58**.
- Three overlapping processes: **Mughal decline → regional autonomy → Company expansion**. European companies initially sought trade; British conquest was not an inevitable outcome visible in 1707.
- Avoid a blanket **"dark age"**: political fragmentation coexisted with regional prosperity, commerce and cultural activity. India was not uniformly economically backward.
- Regional classification in the chapter: **successor states—Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad; new powers—Marathas, Sikhs, Jats, Afghans; established/independent kingdoms—Mysore, Kerala, Rajput states**. These categories describe different trajectories, not identical origins.
- Mughal legitimacy, revenue practices and administrative traditions survived in successor states and Company territories.



Imperial fragmentation created opportunities;
Company conquest was not inevitable.

2. Early Later Mughals: rulers and associations

- **Bahadur Shah I / Muazzam / Shah Alam I (1707–12):** defeated Azam at **Jajau, June 1707**, and Kam Bakhsh near Hyderabad in **January 1709**. More conciliatory than Aurangzeb; made peace with Rajput chiefs, Churaman Jat and Chhatrasal Bundela.
- **Sikhs:** sought accommodation with Guru Gobind Singh; later personally campaigned against **Banda Bahadur at Lohgarh**. Sikh resistance continued. Lohgarh was associated with Banda's headquarters/fortification; do not attribute its construction simply to Guru Gobind Singh. Haryana Gazetteer
- **Shahu:** captive since **1689**, released in **1707**. The chapter associates his return with Bahadur Shah's conciliatory era; Maharashtra Gazetteers specifically attribute the release to **Azam Shah, on Zulfiqar Khan's advice**.
- Bahadur Shah's lavish jagir grants/promotions weakened finances. **Khafi Khan's Shah-i-Bekhabar** means a heedless/unaware ruler; "headless king" is a misleading literal gloss.

- **Jahandar Shah (1712–13):** throne secured through **Zulfiqar Khan**, his powerful wazir. Defeated by nephew **Farrukhsiyar near Agra**; Zulfiqar executed.
- Zulfiqar cultivated Rajput/Maratha support: **Jai Singh II—Malwa; Ajit Singh—Gujarat**. Confirmed the **1711 Daud Khan Panni–Shahu arrangement** for chauth/sardeshmukhi, collected by Mughal officials and passed to Marathas; conciliated Jats/Bundelas, suppressed Sikhs, abolished jizya.
- Checked excessive grants/offices but extended **ijarah—revenue farming**: contractors paid a fixed sum to State and extracted revenue from cultivators; encouraged over-assessment/oppression. Ijarah was not a system invented from nothing in this reign.
- **Farrukhsiyar (1713–19):** installed by **Sayyid Abdullah Khan—wazir; Sayyid Husain Ali Khan—Mir Bakshi**. Their predominance lasted **1713–20**.
- Sayyids pursued accommodation with Hindu chiefs, removed jizya/pilgrimage taxes, reconciled Marathas/Rajputs/Jats; Sikh suppression continued. **Banda Bahadur captured at Gurdas Nangal, near Gurdaspur, 1715; executed at Delhi, 1716**.
- Farrukhsiyar tried to escape Sayyid control; they deposed, blinded and killed him in **1719**, supported by **Peshwa Balaji Vishwanath**. Important instance of nobles directly disposing of an emperor.
- **Rafi-ud-Darajat (1719):** very short reign; died of tuberculosis. **Rafi-ud-Daula / Shah Jahan II (1719):** another short-lived Sayyid nominee; also died of illness. Do not confuse him with Shah Jahan III.



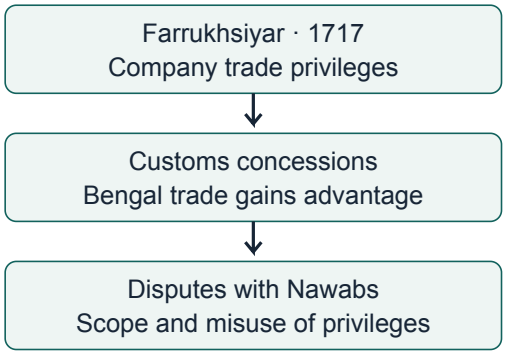
Associate each early ruler with the event or power behind his throne.

3. Court factions and kingmakers

- Four broad groups: **Turanis—Central Asian; Iranis—Persian; Afghans; Hindustanis—India-born Muslims**, often allied with Rajputs/Jats. Turanis/Afghans largely Sunni; Iranis largely Shia.
- Factions were **fluid interest networks**, not permanently united ethnic/religious blocs. Personal ambition, patronage and access to revenue were central.
- Chapter associations: **Irani—Asad Khan/Zulfiqar Khan; Turani—Ghazi-ud-Din Feroz Jung and Chin Qilich Khan / Nizam-ul-Mulk; Hindustani—Sayyid brothers**.
- Earlier nobles backed competing princes; later powerful nobles increasingly **selected, controlled and removed emperors**. No fixed primogeniture rule meant recurrent succession wars.
- Kingmakers: **Zulfiqar → Sayyid brothers → Nizam-ul-Mulk/Muhammad Amin → Imad-ul-Mulk**, followed by growing Rohilla, Maratha and Company control.

4. Farman of 1717: the Company connection

- **Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman** granted important East India Company commercial privileges, notably customs concessions for its Bengal trade.
- **William Hamilton**, Company surgeon, treated the emperor during the diplomatic mission; this helped the embassy secure concessions. Recall **Hamilton → Farrukhsiyar → 1717**, rather than the chapter's uncertain treatment-year detail.
- Privileges strengthened Company trade; their interpretation and misuse became recurring disputes with Bengal Nawabs. **Commercial privilege was not a grant of sovereignty over Bengal**.



The farman strengthened commerce; it did not transfer Bengal sovereignty.

5. Muhammad Shah: regional breakup and invasion

- **Muhammad Shah / Roshan Akhtar / Rangeela (1719–48):** initially a Sayyid nominee; their power was broken in **1720** through rival nobles including Nizam-ul-Mulk/Muhammad Amin Khan. Do not memorise that both brothers were killed together in 1720.
- Long reign failed to restore imperial coordination. Personal court indulgence is one explanation in the chapter; structural pressures are equally important.
- Successor-state anchors: **Murshid Quli Khan—Bengal, 1717; Saadat Khan / Burhan-ul-Mulk—Awadh, 1722; Nizam-ul-Mulk / Qamar-ud-din / Asaf Jah—Hyderabad, 1724**. These were stages of autonomy under continuing Mughal titles, not identical declarations of independence.
- **Baji Rao I's Delhi raid, 1737** exposed northern vulnerability. **Nadir Shah's invasion, 1738–39**, delivered a devastating blow; Abdali's first invasion followed in **1748**.

6. Persian and Afghan invasions: distinguish them

- **Nadir Shah—Persian ruler:** frontier neglect, Mughal disunity and wealth attracted invasion. At **Karnal, 1739**, Muhammad Shah's army was defeated; **Khan-i-Dauran** died, **Saadat Khan** was captured.
- Delhi's massacre and plunder stripped the treasury; **Peacock Throne and Koh-i-Noor** carried away. Chapter estimates loot at **₹70 crore**, enabling three years' Persian tax remission; treat this as a historical estimate, not a modern purchasing-power figure.
- Territories west of the Indus, including Kabul, lost; finances/prestige collapsed and the north-west became more exposed. Poets **Mir and Sauda** lamented Delhi's devastation.

- **Nadir assassinated, 1747; Ahmad Shah Abdali / Durrani founded Afghan power**, taking the title **Durr-i-Durrani, "pearl of pearls"**. He was not Nadir's successor as ruler of Persia.
- Chapter counts **seven invasions, 1748–67**. Key sequence: **1748 first repulsed; 1749 pressure on Punjab/Muin-ul-Mulk; 1752 Punjab and Multan ceded; 1756–57 Delhi plundered; 1759–61 campaign culminating in Panipat; further expeditions up to 1767**. Campaign totals vary with how expeditions are counted.
- After Muin-ul-Mulk's death, **Adina Beg's Punjab appointment** intensified conflict. In **1757**, Abdali recognised **Alamgir II—emperor; Imad-ul-Mulk—wazir; Najib-ud-Daulah—Mir Bakshi; son Timur Shah—Afghan representative**, linked to the Mughal family by marriage.
- **1758:** Raghunath Rao's Marathas expelled Afghan influence from Delhi, overran Punjab/Lahore, displaced Timur and installed **Adina Beg** under Peshwa **Balaji Baji Rao**.
- **14 January 1761, Third Battle of Panipat:** Abdali defeated Marathas; checked their northern ascendancy, but did not restore effective all-India Mughal rule. Marathas later recovered influence at Delhi.
- **Najib-ud-Daulah:** Rohilla chief, Abdali ally, founder of **Najibabad**; distinguish his son **Zabita Khan** and grandson **Ghulam Qadir**.



Keep Persian and Afghan rulers, campaigns and outcomes distinct.

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7. Later rulers: from court puppets to Company protection

- **Ahmad Shah Bahadur (1748–54):** weak ministry dominated by mother **Udham Bai / Qibla-i-Alam** and **Javid Khan**; Punjab/Multan ceded to Abdali in **1752**. **Imad-ul-Mulk / Ghazi-ud-Din Feroz Jung III** emerged as kingmaker; emperor deposed/blinded in **1754** with Maratha support.
- **Alamgir II / Aziz-ud-din (1754–59):** Jahandar Shah's son, raised by Imad. **Plassey—23 June 1757** during his reign; Abdali's Delhi sack and subsequent Maratha intervention. Murdered on Imad's orders in **1759**.
- **Shah Jahan III / Muhi-ul-Millat (1759–60):** Imad's short-lived puppet; descended from **Kam Bakhsh**. His claim overlapped **Shah Alam II's**; therefore do not force the succession into a perfectly non-overlapping list.
- **Shah Alam II / Ali Gauhar (1759–1806; chapter also uses 1760):** spent early reign outside Delhi because of hostile court politics and insecure authority; later recognised by Afghan/Maratha powers.
- **Buxar, 1764:** Shah Alam II + **Mir Qasim of Bengal + Shuja-ud-Daulah of Awadh** defeated by Company. **Allahabad settlement, 1765:** Company obtained **Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa**; emperor received **₹26 lakh annual payment** and **Kora/Allahabad**, residing at Allahabad.
- **1771–72:** Marathas under **Mahadji Shinde / Scindia** enabled his return to Delhi, completed in **January 1772**. He relied on Maratha protection; campaigns against Zabita followed in **1772–73**.

- **1788:** Ghulam Qadir seized palace and blinded Shah Alam; Mahadji restored him later that year. Recall **“fugitive emperor”** → **“blind emperor”**; Rohilla family members' influence occurred at different times, not all throughout his exile.
- **1803:** Company under **Lord Lake** captured Delhi from Scindia's forces during Second Anglo-Maratha War; emperor came under British protection.
- **Aftab:** Shah Alam's poetic pen-name. Saying **“Sultanat-e-Shah Alam, az Dilli ta Palam”** captures his reduced authority—Delhi to Palam.
- **Akbar II (1806–37):** penultimate emperor; conferred **Raja** on **Ram Mohan Roy**, sent him to Britain to seek improved imperial allowance. **1835:** Company coinage ceased carrying the Mughal emperor's name.
- **Bahadur Shah II / Zafar (1837–57):** poet-emperor, accepted as symbolic sovereign by 1857 rebels; captured after Delhi fell. Tried/deported to **Rangoon, 1858**; died **November 1862**.
- **1857–58:** dynasty removed. **1 November 1858, Queen Victoria's Proclamation** marks Crown takeover from Company; do not confuse it with Zafar's death or treat it as the beginning of Mughal political weakness.



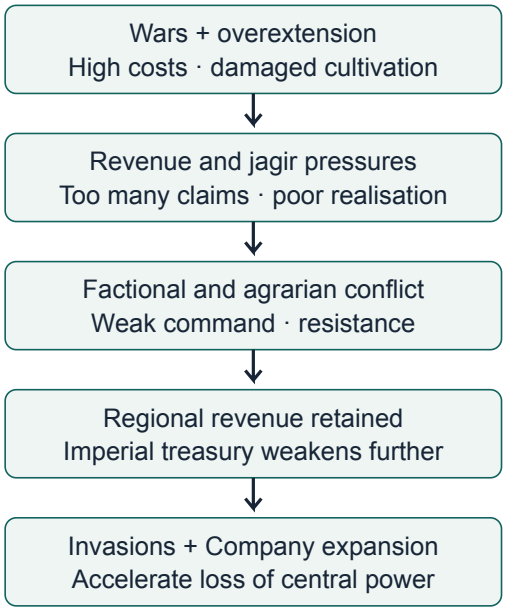
The dynasty survived while effective power shifted to other actors.

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8. Why the Empire declined: interacting causes

- **Overextension/Deccan wars:** Aurangzeb's prolonged campaigns outran communications and administrative capacity; war expenditure, devastated crops and disrupted collections weakened the centre. The **“Deccan ulcer”** analogy compares this drain with Napoleon's Spanish war.
- **Political/religious conflict:** Aurangzeb's policies strained some Rajput, Sikh, Jat and Maratha relationships. Revolts also involved local power, land and revenue; a purely Hindu–Muslim explanation is inadequate.
- **Weak imperial coordination:** personal-monarchy dependence, incompetent successors, succession wars, factional patronage and puppet rulers damaged continuity and command.
- **Nobility/army:** luxury and competition for offices distracted elites; fragmented contingents, weak supervision, unwieldy camp followers, uneven military adaptation and poor coordination reduced effectiveness.

- **Jagirdari crisis:** too many claimants for remunerative assignments, gap between expected/realised revenue and administrative/military costs → competition for good jagirs → factional conflict, under-maintained contingents and regional autonomy.
- **Agrarian distress:** heavy revenue demand, revenue farming, frequent transfers and war damage encouraged short-term extraction; cultivators' capacity to pay declined, flight/rebellion rose.
- **Zamindars:** hereditary local rights, armed followings and collection roles made them influential intermediaries; names included **Rais, Rajas, Khuts, Thakurs, Deshmukhs**. Shifting loyalties could support local rebellions or provincial autonomy.
- **Fiscal erosion:** long wars, court costs, invasion/plunder and provinces retaining revenues depleted the imperial treasury. Shah Jahan's building expenditure is a chapter example, not a sufficient explanation of eighteenth-century collapse.
- **Regional ascendancy:** Marathas expanded north; Sikh/Jat/Rajput and other powers asserted autonomy; successful provincial networks diverted resources from Delhi.
- **External shocks:** Persian/Afghan invasions revealed and deepened existing weakness; European companies exploited military and court rivalries, converting commercial footholds into political power.
- **Terminology corrections:** a **mansab** was an imperial rank, not simply hereditary office; a **jagir** was generally a revenue assignment, not automatic permanent land ownership. **Zamindar and jagirdar are not interchangeable**. “Police state” is a simplifying textbook label, not the full scope of Mughal government.



A reinforcing crisis links finance, political power and military capacity.

9. Historians: explanation → association

- **William Irvine; Jadunath Sarkar → personal failings, court/nobility decline; Sarkar emphasised Aurangzeb's religious policy.** Their moral/religious framing should be assessed critically.
- **Satish Chandra; M. Athar Ali → mansabdari–jagirdari pressures**, shortage of suitable assignments relative to claims and instability in ruling-class arrangements.
- **Irfan Habib → agrarian crisis:** excessive extraction, peasant resistance and transfer-driven short-term exploitation undermined revenue and stability.

- **M.N. Pearson; J.F. Richards; P. Hardy → Deccan/Maratha conflict** and the burden of prolonged military commitments.
- **Muzaffar Alam; Chetan Singh → regional developments**, especially Awadh/Punjab; stronger provincial economies and groups asserted autonomy while the imperial centre weakened.
- **Evaluation:** multi-causal, regionally uneven transformation. Political decline at Delhi did not mean economic/cultural collapse everywhere; Mughal administrative legitimacy could survive loss of effective command.

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10. PYQ revision

- **UPSC Prelims 2003—Shah Alam II Assertion–Reason:** assertion says early imperial years were outside Delhi; reason attributes this to an always-lurking north-west invasion danger. **Printed key: (c), A true, R false.** Recall his exile and hostile court politics; this answer does not mean Afghan invasions never occurred.
- **UPSC Prelims 2003—Jahandar's early end: (c), defeated by his nephew in battle**. Link **Jahandar → Farrukhsiyar → Agra**, not deposition by his own wazir.

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11. One-minute recall / Mains structure

- **1707 death → 1717 farman → 1737 Delhi raid → 1739 Karnal/sack → 1757 Plassey → 1761 Panipat → 1764 Buxar → 1765 Diwani → 1772 return → 1788 blinding → 1803 Company Delhi → 1857–58 dynasty ends.**
- Distinguish **Bahadur Shah I/II; Shah Alam I/II; Ahmad Shah Bahadur/Abdali; Balaji Vishwanath/Baji Rao I/Balaji Baji Rao; Shah Jahan II/III**.
- Mains: distinguish imperial authority from regional economy → political, military, fiscal and agrarian links → invasions as accelerants → historians' contrasting explanations → continuity alongside fragmentation.

NCERT: Mughal agrarian institutions and revenue

IGNOU: eighteenth-century regional polities

Maharashtra Gazetteers: Shahu's release